Nasser A. Marohomsalic

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Atty. Nasser A. Marohomsalic

Atty. Nasser A. Marohomsalic (July 21, 1955 to July 6, 2024) was a Maranao lawyer, historian, novelist, and human rights advocate who spent his career championing justice for the Bangsamoro people and advocating for the intersection of Islamic tradition and democratic governance.<ref name="NDBC">Peace Sec. Galvez on passing of NAC Commissioner Nasser Marohomsalic. Notre Dame Broadcasting Corporation (NDBC) News, 2024.</ref> He served as the **first Bangsamoro commissioner of the Commission on Human Rights (CHR)** during the 2nd Commission term, spanning from May 5, 1994, to May 5, 2001,<ref name="CHR">Commission on Human Rights Commission En Banc. CHR Official Records, 1994-2001.</ref> and was sitting as a commissioner of the National Amnesty Commission at the time of his death. Marohomsalic left an indelible mark on Philippine human rights, peace advocacy, and Bangsamoro intellectual life through his institutional work, his prolific historical and literary writings, and his unwavering belief that amnesty and dialogue were the pathways to national healing.

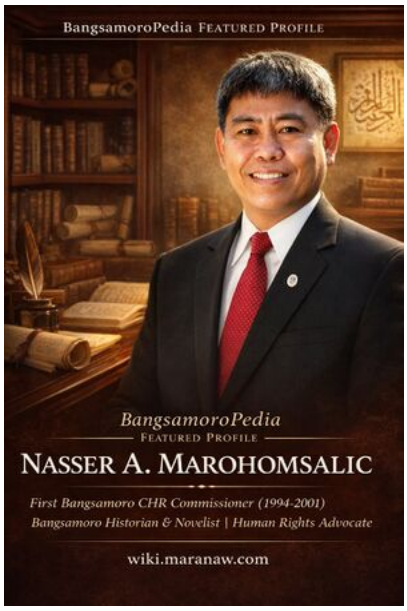
Early Life and Education

Marohomsalic was born on July 21, 1955, in Lumba-Bayabao, Lanao del Sur, the heart of Meranaw territory. He began his tertiary education at Mindanao State University-Main Campus as an honors student before relocating to Manila to complete his undergraduate studies. He earned his Bachelor of Arts in Political Science from Far Eastern University in 1977, then pursued legal studies at the University of the Philippines, where he completed his Bachelor of Laws in 1981.<ref name="NDBC" />

He was married to Hadja Omensalam Benito Adap Cotigal and fathered six children, among them Atty. Nashmyleen A. Marohomsalic, who would go on to become the first Filipina and first Bangsamoro lawyer admitted as counsel before the International Criminal Court.<ref name="BARMM">Bangsamoro Parliament. Resolution No. 492: Commending Atty. Nashmyleen A. Marohomsalic. August 2024.</ref>

Colleagues and friends knew him affectionately as "Tito Nas," a mentor figure described by those close to him as more like family than a professional peer, known for his lighthearted humor and ready willingness to help anyone in need.<ref name="Memoir">Personal memoir, author acquaintance. 2025.</ref>

Nasser A. Marohomsalic



Birth	July 21, 1955
Death	July 6, 2024
Place of origin	Ganassi, Lanao del Sur
Ethnicity	Maranao
Education	Bachelor of Arts (Political Science), Far Eastern University, 1977; Bachelor of Laws, University of the Philippines, 1981
Notable positions	CHR Commissioner (1994-2001); National Secretary, Integrated Bar of the Philippines; NAC Commissioner; PCID Co-founder
Religion	Islam
Spouse	Hadja Omensalam Benito Adap Cotigal
Children	Six, including Atty. Nashmyleen A. Marohomsalic (ICC counsel)

Legal Career and Institutional Roles

Commission on Human Rights (1994-2001)

In 1994, President Fidel Ramos appointed Marohomsalic as a Commissioner of the Commission on Human Rights, marking a historic moment: he became the first Bangsamoro to sit on the CHR.

<ref name="NDBC" /> During his seven-year tenure, he earned a reputation as a vocal champion for the marginalized, particularly indigenous Muslim communities. He was known for visiting displaced communities and wounded security personnel alike, emphasizing that their human rights were equally protected under law. When Mayor Alfredo Lim's administration in Manila launched the notorious "spray-painting" campaign against suspected drug pushers in 1997, Marohomsalic was among the CHR voices that publicly tangled with this extrajudicial practice, refusing to see human rights as selective.<ref name="OnMaranao">On Maranao. Blogspot, 2025.</ref>

His work at the CHR transcended bureaucratic procedure. He published *Towards Peace, Autonomy, and Human Rights* (1999), a collection of his speeches and positions from those years, arguing that true peace requires both institutional accountability and community healing.

Integrated Bar of the Philippines (National Secretary)

Marohomsalic made history as the **first Maranao elected as National Secretary of the Integrated Bar of the Philippines**,<ref name="NDBC" /> a position that gave him a platform to ensure Muslim Filipino representation in the Philippine legal community. His tenure underscored his belief that the bar itself should reflect the diversity of the nation it served, not exclude it.

National Amnesty Commission (1990s-2024)

At the time of his death in July 2024, Marohomsalic was serving as a Commissioner of the National Amnesty Commission (NAC), where he had become instrumental in implementing the government's reconciliation programs.

<ref name="NAC">National Amnesty Commission Official Records.</ref> His role overseeing amnesty processing touched thousands of applications from the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF), Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF), and former communist rebels.

Marohomsalic held a philosophical view of amnesty that transcended legalism. He famously stated that "everything follows after peace,"<ref name="SourceDoc">Nasser A. Marohomsalic. NAC Position Papers and Speeches, 1990s-2024.</ref> viewing amnesty not as a mere legal procedure but as a "motherhood of all virtues" essential for national stability and the reintegration of former combatants. He clarified a crucial legal principle: that amnesty covers crimes committed in pursuit of political beliefs but does not erase civil liabilities, a distinction he championed to encourage former rebels to return to the fold of law.

He was instrumental in establishing Local Amnesty Boards (LABs) across the country, ensuring that eligible individuals in remote or conflict-affected areas could access the amnesty process without traveling to distant offices. This was not mere procedural convenience; it was an expression of his belief that peace infrastructure should reach the people, not require the people to reach it.

Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy (PCID)

Marohomsalic was a founding member of the Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy, where he worked alongside other Muslim and non-Muslim intellectuals to counter the false narrative that Islam and democratic governance were inherently incompatible.

<ref name="PCID">Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy Official Records. https://www.pcid.com.ph</ref> His intellectual contribution to this organization centered on bridging two traditions that many in the West (and regrettably, some in the Philippines) falsely opposed. He demonstrated through institutional work and scholarly writing that Islamic principles of justice and consultation (*shura*) not only coexist with democratic ideals but enrich them.

Scholarship and Literary Work

Marohomsalic's intellectual legacy rests on his dual identity as historian and novelist, roles that allowed him to serve Bangsamoro consciousness on multiple registers.

Aristocrats of the Malay Race (1995/2001)

His seminal work, *Aristocrats of the Malay Race: A History of the Bangsa Moro in the Philippines*, was self-published in 2001 after a decade of research and writing. The book provides a comprehensive historical account of Bangsamoro resistance to Spanish, American, and Philippine central authority, framed explicitly as a registry of both aspirations and grievances.<ref name="OnMaranao" /> It is widely used as a primary text in understanding the Bangsamoro struggle from a local, humanizing perspective, shifting the narrative from "rebellion" to a defense of noble identity.

The book sold out immediately upon release, a testament to its resonance with readers seeking a Bangsamoro-authored account of Bangsamoro history.

<ref name="Amazon">Aristocrats of the Malay Race: A History of the Bangsa Moro in the Philippines. Amazon.com Book Review Database, accessed 2024.</ref>

Maratabat: A Novel on Rido and Revenge Justice (2024)

In his final work, launched in June 2024 at Mindanao State University-Marawi just weeks before his passing, Marohomsalic shifted to fiction to explore the Meranaw concept of *maratabat* (personal and lineal honor) and how it fuels *rido* (clan feuding). The novel is structured around two central, deeply embedded concepts that dictate social behavior and conflict resolution in Lanao:

> *Maratabat* is a deep sense of personal honor, dignity, and self-esteem, but unlike Western concepts of individual pride, it is collective. It is tied to one's lineage (*bangsa*) and rank. Upholding one's honor is synonymous with protecting the reputation of the entire clan.

The novel portrays *maratabat* as a double-edged sword: a source of immense pride and resilience, but also a force that can lead to what Marohomsalic called "an irrational choice of death over loss of face." *Rido*, by contrast, is a cyclical system of retaliatory violence between families, often triggered by offenses to *maratabat* ranging from petty insults to serious crimes, and capable of persisting across generations.

The thematic heart of *Maratabat* is a warning to younger generations: while *maratabat* was historically a code of nobility and chivalry, it has been modernly "warped" into a justification for destructive revenge violence. Through his characters, Marohomsalic advocated for a "Maratabat Reimagined," shifting the focus from retaliation to finding honor in peacebuilding, community service, and education. This was not Marohomsalic abandoning tradition; it was him honoring it by asking Meranaw society to remember what maratabat truly means in the service of life.

The Mujahidin (Unfinished)

At the time of his passing, Marohomsalic had been working on *The Mujahidin*, a novel set in the conflict zones of Mindanao. The manuscript remains with close friends and family, incomplete but bearing the promise of his final artistic vision.

<ref name="OnMaranao" />

Cultural Significance and Peace Advocacy

Marohomsalic's intellectual work, whether historical or literary, served a singular purpose: to document, defend, and elevate Bangsamoro identity and agency in Philippine consciousness. He was a custodian of Bangsamoro memory in an era when that memory was often marginalized or distorted.

Beyond the written word, he served as a publicity ambassador for **Heavenly Culture, World Peace, Restoration of Light (HWPL) Philippines**,<ref name="SourceDoc" /> cementing his status as a voice for harmony at regional and global levels.

His belief in dialogue over demonization, in amnesty over vengeance, and in the dignity of his people permeated every role he held. Whether sitting on the CHR, chairing amnesty boards, or writing novels late into the evening, Marohomsalic treated peacebuilding not as a policy goal but as a moral imperative rooted in Islamic tradition and

democratic principle.

Family Legacy and Continuing Impact

Atty. Nashmyleen A. Marohomsalic and the International Criminal Court

Marohomsalic's commitment to justice and education continues through the achievements of his daughter, Atty. Nashmyleen A. Marohomsalic. In 2024, she became the **first Filipina and first Bangsamoro lawyer** to be admitted as counsel before the International Criminal Court.<ref name="BARMM" /> She is one of only five Filipino lawyers accredited by the International Criminal Court Bar Association, allowing her to represent victims, defendants, or witnesses in cases involving genocide, war crimes, and crimes against humanity.

Her achievement was formally recognized by the Bangsamoro Parliament through Resolution No. 492, which commended her for breaking ground in international legal representation. She holds a degree in Philosophy from the University of the Philippines and a Juris Doctor from Ateneo de Manila University.<ref name="BARMM" />

Nasser Marohomsalic Lecture Series on Justice, Peace, and Liberty

In late 2025, nearly a year after Marohomsalic's passing, the Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy launched the **Nasser Marohomsalic Lecture Series on Justice, Peace, and Liberty** in his honor, serving as a platform for intellectual discourse on the values he championed throughout his life.<ref name="PCID" />

The inaugural session was opened by Atty. Christian Monsod, a framer of the 1987 Constitution of the Philippines. Lectures focus on the intersection of social justice, the rule of law, and the empowerment of marginalized communities. The series explicitly bridges Islamic principles and democratic ideals, reflecting Marohomsalic's lifelong commitment to showing that these traditions are not enemies but allies in the pursuit of justice.

Death and Commemoration

Atty. Nasser A. Marohomsalic passed away on July 6, 2024, at the age of 68. The Bangsamoro Parliament passed a resolution recognizing his immense contributions to peacebuilding, human rights, and civil service. At the moment of his death, he remained a sitting commissioner of the National Amnesty Commission, a role he held with the same dedication and moral clarity that defined his entire career.

His final novel, *Maratabat*, was launched posthumously, a final gift to Bangsamoro and Philippine letters from a man who believed that literature and law were both instruments of human dignity.

Further Reading

- Marohomsalic, Nasser A. (2001). *Aristocrats of the Malay Race: A History of the Bangsa Moro in the Philippines*. Self-published.
- Marohomsalic, Nasser A. (1999). *Towards Peace, Autonomy, and Human Rights*. Collection of speeches as CHR Commissioner.
- Marohomsalic, Nasser A. (2024). *Maratabat: A Novel on Rido and Revenge Justice*. Mindanao State University Press.
- "On Maranao" (2025). Personal memorial essay on Nasser Marohomsalic. Blogspot.

See Also

- Commission on Human Rights (Philippines)
- National Amnesty Commission (Philippines)
- Integrated Bar of the Philippines
- Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy
- Bangsamoro people
- Maranao people
- Nashmyleen A. Marohomsalic
- International Criminal Court

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